



geek life

Breakpoint, held in Germany every year is the biggest pure demoparty (a demoparty without a LAN party). The scene.org awards are given in this event.

buffer memory and the RAM hacked to accommodate the requirements of the demo. Programmers in the scene discovered new ways to use shaders and 3D models, smart approaches to combine live synthesis of sound with pre-recorded samples, and outrageous use of coding tricks. Demos increasingly became versatile with random elements. These approaches and methods were often reverse engineered or mimicked by rival groups and used for their own demos. Arrogance at coding or design capability, and respect towards such talent are two mainstays of the demoscene. The most well known or popular groups were treated and behaved like rockstars.

Early trading parties involved a bunch of people meeting up to exchange disks and collaborate on parties. Later on, demos and software were exchanged over the internet, through the use of modems. The proliferation of the internet allowed for an easy way to spread demos, modifying the role of a swapper in the group. The swapper became the public face of the group, posting on forums, registering for parties, representing the group at meets and the like. With an increasing focus on the demos themselves, the crackers also phased out. A lot of demo programmers still cracked software, but the association with software was removed by the emergence of demoparties, where demos by different groups were showcased independent of any affiliation. The movement still remained mostly underground, and cracked versions of software still carry demos even now, but the vast majority of the demoscene gradually became more focussed on the art of the demo, moving away from any criminal associations with software pirates.

Bulletin boards were maintained by some groups, through the agency of which the group collaborated and released demos. Diskmags for the demoscene emerged which were periodical releases of a collection of the best demos on a floppy disk. A diskmag typically had user-rated charts for the best demos, appearing on which was considered the biggest token of recognition in the demoscene. The community developed around the demo, meeting up, socialising, and sharing a feeling of belonging to the same family, the same dedicated bunch of coders with a common purpose. Some of the early demos threw up better graphics than the games of that time. A lot of the coders in the demoscene also coded games, or made mods for existing games.

The early Windows-based demos were restricted for a number of reasons. The platform itself was limited in terms of capability, and the existing coders had to learn new languages. A new generation of coders started coding demos on Windows, and diskmags gained a lot of ground in the early 1990s. The internet allowed for better collaborative efforts over longer ranges, and forums allowed for newbies to learn the ins and outs of coding. Demogroups were considerably reduced in size, because distribution and cracking software were no longer really relevant. Demoparties

were organised on larger scales across Europe, often combined with LAN parties. Videos and sampled loops instead of synthesised music were considered more acceptable for ease of distribution. The focus shifted heavily to artistic demos, moving away from flashes, blips, spectral forms and fractals, to smooth flowing 3D animations such as highly detailed models, fluids or particle animations. Demoparties started having segments for judging and voting

on demos. All the old platforms were still allowed, with 4-KB or 64-KB limits, increasingly called "intros" as against "demos". Demos were allowed in 256 KB, 1 MB and upwards, sometimes with no upper limit. Synthesised music itself became a category at demo parties. Individuals were often proficient at both coding and synthesising, a necessity as the groups became smaller.

With the growth of software piracy for Windows, demos started making a comeback along with cracked versions of programs. The coveted titles or an important version release of a program carried demos along with them. These demos, however, were just for identifying the cracker or group, and were short but spectacular. Demoparties became more organised, sponsors were arranged for them, and large gatherings from the scene were organised in European nations, particularly Germany, Russia and Finland. Some of the more recent demo parties showcased demos on large LCD screens, and involved lengthy and elaborate sequences. Within the scene, enthusiasts still code for the old platforms, and some obscure devices, ranging from programmable calculators to hand-held videogame consoles. Modern computers have varying graphic capabilities. Not all demos can be distributed as a real-time rendering standalone program as the performance may vary dramatically from machine to machine. Some will simply not be capable. Most of demos nowadays are distributed as video files, but that does not mean that they are mere animations. The focus is still on programming, and the demos maintain the format of the older demos, with a sequence and a "splash" every now and then. In recent times, crackers of X-Box and PlayStation games also started including demos along with the cracked versions of the games for these consoles. This kickstarted another alternative scene, for consoles. Demos programmed for these consoles are distributed as ISO disk-image files.

Although the glory days of the demoscene are long gone, the scene itself is still alive and kicking. The feeling of bonhomie is much greater, and the focus is on style and method more than ever. Innovation and ability are still respected. Diskmags are still active, and still release issues, even if they are sporadic. The demoscene is still the large, highly competitive family that it was, and produces great art for those who know where to look.■

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